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what role did casper weinberger play in shutting down MKUltra

[Caspar Weinberger]

did not play a direct role in the initial shutdown of **Project MKUltra**, which was officially terminated by the CIA in **1973**.

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The program's closure was primarily driven by:

- **Sidney Gottlieb and Richard Helms:** In 1973, then-CIA Director Richard Helms and MKUltra head Sidney Gottlieb agreed to wind down the program and **ordered the destruction of most of its records** to avoid public scandal and potential prosecution.
- **Internal Oversight:** John Vance of the CIA Inspector General's staff had previously discovered the project's non-consensual human testing in 1963, leading to an initial reduction in the program's scope and more stringent ethics guidelines.

History.com +2

Weinberger's Indirect Connection

While Weinberger was not a central figure in MKUltra's termination, his career intersected with the fallout of the project's discovery:

- **HEW Secretary (1973–1975):** As the Secretary of Health, Education, and Welfare, Weinberger led a department that oversaw many of the institutions (hospitals and universities) where MKUltra research had been surreptitiously conducted.

- **Congressional Disclosure:** The existence of MKUltra was only fully revealed to the public in **1975** through the Church Committee and the Rockefeller Commission.
- **Intelligence Reform:** Following these investigations, President Gerald Ford issued an **Executive Order in 1976** prohibiting non-consensual drug experimentation on human subjects. Weinberger's primary historical legacy remains his tenure as Secretary of Defense under Ronald Reagan, where he focused on military buildup and the Weinberger Doctrine.

8 sites

- MKUltra - Wikipedia
  The program engaged in illegal activities, including the use of U.S. and Canadian citizens as unwitting test subjects. MKUltra's s...

  Wikipedia

- Caspar W. Weinberger - OSD Historical Office
  Rather than reinstituting the draft, a step both he and Reagan rejected, Weinberger placed high priority on increasing the compens...

  Office of the Secretary of Defense Historical Office (.gov)

- Weinberger Doctrine - Wikipedia
  The Weinberger Doctrine asserts that: The United States should not commit forces to combat unless the vital national interests of ...

  Wikipedia

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so, did that involve the Haight-Ashbury Free Clinic or St. Mary's Hospital?

The connections between MKUltra and these San Francisco institutions involve different levels of historical evidence, ranging from documented CIA safe houses to speculative links in popular literature.

Haight-Ashbury Free Clinic

The clinic's connection to MKUltra is primarily **speculative** and popularized by recent investigative books like Tom O'Neill's *CHAOS*.

- **Dr. Louis "Jolly" West**

  : West was a documented MKUltra subproject contractor. In 1967, he rented a "hippie pad" in the Haight-Ashbury district to study the counterculture.

- **Charles Manson**

: Critics and researchers point out that Manson and his "Family" frequented the Haight-Ashbury Free Clinic for medical care during the same period Dr. West was active in the area.

- **Evidence:** While West's CIA ties are factual, there is **no definitive proof** that the clinic itself was a CIA front or that

  Manson

  was an experimental subject there.

  Wikipedia +5

St. Mary's Hospital

There is **no documented evidence** that
St. Mary's Medical Center
was a site for MKUltra research.

UC San Francisco

- **Confusion with "Operation Midnight Climax":** This famous MKUltra subproject involved CIA safe houses in San Francisco (notably at 225 Chestnut Street) where prostitutes lured men to be surreptitiously dosed with LSD. These were private apartments, not established hospitals.
- **Institutional Scope:** While the CIA used 80 different institutions (including Stanford and UCSF), St. Mary's is not among the publicly confirmed sites in declassified records.

  The New York Times +4

Caspar Weinberger's Role

As previously noted, Weinberger's role was **administrative**, not operational. He headed the department (HEW) that oversaw the hospitals and universities that *did* participate in the research. However, by the time he took office in 1973, the CIA had already begun destroying files and shutting down the program.

People.com +3

Are you researching a specific **individual** or **subproject** that you believe might be linked to these hospitals?

14 sites

- Haight Ashbury Free Clinic - Wikipedia

Louis Jolyon West—a LSD researcher involved in MKUltra—lived near the clinic, and was allowed by Smith to recruit clients for expe...

Wikipedia

- MKUltra - Wikipedia
  Alleged subjects: * James "Whitey" Bulger, an organized crime boss, alleged he had been subjected to weekly injections of LSD and ...

  Wikipedia

- The CIA's Appalling Human Experiments With Mind Control
  Though the CIA piloted these safe houses as a stage for testing the effects of LSD, White's interest shifted to another element of...

  History.com

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But the HEW over saw St Mary's and the HAFMC, right?

While the **Department of Health, Education, and Welfare (HEW)** did have regulatory and funding oversight of various medical institutions, its relationship with the **Haight-Ashbury Free Medical Clinic (HAFMC)** and **St. Mary's Hospital** was markedly different:

1. Haight-Ashbury Free Medical Clinic (HAFMC)

- **Initial Independence:** Founded in 1967 by **Dr. David Smith**, the HAFMC initially operated as a purely volunteer, grassroots organization that explicitly **rejected government oversight** and funding.
- **Federal Funding Era:** It was not until the early 1970s—specifically during Caspar Weinberger's tenure at HEW—that the clinic began receiving **federal grants** through the Special Action Office for Drug Abuse Prevention to treat heroin addiction among Vietnam veterans.
- **HEW Oversight:** This funding brought the clinic under HEW's regulatory umbrella for drug treatment standards. However, critics like **Tom O'Neill** argue this "oversight" provided a layer of legitimacy for figures like **Dr. Louis "Jolyon" West**, an MKUltra contractor who lived near and recruited subjects from the clinic.

Wikipedia +5

2.

St. Mary's Hospital

- **Private Catholic Institution:** As a private, non-profit Catholic hospital, St. Mary's was not "owned" or directly operated by the HEW.
- **Regulatory Oversight:** Like all hospitals receiving **Medicare and Medicaid** funds (which were administered by HEW), St. Mary's had to comply with federal health standards.
- **Rejection of Counterculture:** Historically, St. Mary's was known for **refusing to treat** the "hippie" population of the Haight-Ashbury district for drug-related issues, which was the primary reason Dr. Smith founded the Free Clinic in the first place.

HHS.gov +3

Summary of Weinberger's Role

As Secretary of HEW (1973–1975), **Caspar Weinberger** oversaw the massive expansion of federal health funding and the implementation of the HMO Act of 1973. While he was the "top boss" of the department that funded the HAFMC's detox programs, there is no evidence he was aware of or directed any clandestine MKUltra-linked activities at these specific sites. His primary focus was **budgetary reform** and the commercialization of healthcare.

Are you interested in the **specific federal grants** these institutions received during the Weinberger era, or the **investigations** that later uncovered these links?

13 sites

- HHS Historical Highlights
  Mar 14, 2023 — The Department of Health, Education, and Welfare (HEW) became the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) on May 4, 1980. Th...

  HHS.gov
- Haight Ashbury Free Clinic - Wikipedia
  People would frequently enter the clinic with superficial injuries, likely to get a feel for the vibes before voicing their real p...

  Wikipedia

- No, it was not illegal to profit off U.S. healthcare before a Nixon ...

May 1, 2019 — No, it was not illegal to profit off U.S. healthcare before a Nixon-era law. An Internet post about the commercialization of Ameri...

PolitiFact

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yes

While

Caspar Weinberger's

tenure as Secretary of Health, Education, and Welfare (HEW) coincided with the public exposure of MKUltra, his role was primarily that of a top-level administrator overseeing the agencies that began funding these institutions as they moved from clandestine CIA sponsorship to legitimate federal support.

Federal Funding to HAFMC and St. Mary's

The funding of these institutions during the Weinberger era (1973–1975) reflects a shift from secret experimentation to public health initiatives:

- **Haight-Ashbury Free Medical Clinic (HAFMC)**

  :

  - **The Special Action Office Grant:** In 1973, the Special Action Office for Drug Abuse Prevention (SAODAP), which operated under HEW's umbrella, awarded the

    HAFMC

    its first major federal grant for heroin detoxification.

  - **The Vietnam Connection:** This funding was specifically intended to treat the influx of **Vietnam veterans** returning with opioid addictions.

  - **Oversight:** As HEW Secretary, Weinberger oversaw the SAODAP and the National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA), which regularized the

    HAFMC's

    operations. This effectively moved the clinic from a radical, volunteer-run "hippie" outpost to a federally funded medical provider.

- **St. Mary's Hospital**

  :

  - **Standard Federal Support:** Unlike the

HAFMC

,

St. Mary's

was an established private hospital. Its "funding" from HEW during Weinberger's term consisted of **Medicare and Medicaid reimbursements** rather than specific research grants related to behavior control.

- **No MKUltra Record:** There is no declassified evidence that

  St. Mary's

  received secret MKUltra subproject funds. Most documented San Francisco CIA safe houses (like those in Operation Midnight Climax) were private residences, not hospitals.

UC San Francisco +6

Investigations Uncovering the Links

The connection between federal agencies and these institutions was uncovered years later through major government inquiries:

1. **The Church Committee (1975):** This Senate investigation officially revealed that the CIA had used **80 different institutions**, including hospitals and universities, for MKUltra research.
2. **The Rockefeller Commission (1975):** Investigated CIA activities within the U.S., highlighting the surreptitious testing of LSD in San Francisco.
3. **Modern Investigative Research:** Books like

   CHAOS

   by Tom O'Neill have used declassified records to argue that MKUltra contractors, like Dr. Louis Jolyon West, utilized their proximity to the

   HAFMC

   to observe or recruit subjects, even if the clinic's founder was unaware of the CIA's underlying interest.

dlab @ EPFL

Weinberger's "Cap the Knife" reputation meant he was focused on **cutting the HEW budget** rather than managing secret intelligence programs. By the time he arrived at HEW, the CIA had already destroyed the majority of MKUltra's operational files.

Would you like to look closer at the specific **MKUltra subprojects** that were confirmed to have taken place in the San Francisco area?

12 sites

- Caspar W. Weinberger - OSD Historical Office
  He moved to Washington in January 1970 to become chairman of the Federal Trade Commission, subsequently serving as deputy director...

  Office of the Secretary of Defense Historical Office (.gov)

- Born in the Summer of Love: The Haight Ashbury Free Clinic ...
  Jun 7, 2017 — He leased a former dentist's office at 558 Clayton St., near the corner of Haight Street, and called it David E. Smith, MD, and As...

  UC San Francisco

- Haight Ashbury's Free Health Clinic Still Groovy - NPR
  Jan 22, 2017 — Smith says he saw many Vietnam veterans returning from the war in the early 1970s who were addicted to heroin. They felt ostracize...

  NPR

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yes

In the San Francisco area, MKUltra research was characterized by a split between **clandestine street operations** and **academic medical research**.

1. Operation Midnight Climax (Subproject 42)

This was the most infamous of the San Francisco operations, involving "safe houses" where the CIA observed unwitting citizens.

Wikipedia +1

- **The "Pads":** The primary location was a swanky apartment at 225 Chestnut Street on Telegraph Hill. A second safe house was located in

  Mill Valley

  .

- **The Methodology:** Prostitutes on the CIA payroll lured men to these apartments, where they were surreptitiously dosed with **LSD**.

- **Surveillance:** CIA agent **George Hunter White** observed the subjects through one-way mirrors while sitting on a portable toilet and drinking martinis.
- **The Goal:** To study how drugs and sexual entrapment could be used to extract secrets or induce "involuntary actions".

Wikipedia +6

2. Academic Subprojects (Stanford & UCSF)

While the safe houses were run by narcotics agents, several MKUltra subprojects were embedded in legitimate medical institutions.

Wikipedia +2

- **Stanford University (Subproject 86):** Documents show the CIA provided funds to the Department of Medicine's Neurology Division at Stanford. This project focused on developing and evaluating **miniature polygraph equipment** and finding more reliable ways to estimate "stress reactions" in human beings.
- **Stanford University (Subprojects 2, 56, 70, 71, 72, 85):** These additional subprojects, which included research on **psychoactive drugs**, were formally acknowledged when the CIA sent photocopies of invoices and receipts to the university in 1977.
- **Institutional Fronts:** These research projects were often funded through the Geshickter Fund for Medical Research, a front organization that allowed the CIA to sponsor academic studies without the researchers (or their subjects) knowing the true source of the money.

Wikipedia +4

3. The Manson/Haight-Ashbury Link

Though not an official "subproject" like the others, the Haight-Ashbury Free Clinic is linked to MKUltra through **Dr. Louis Jolyon West**.

National Security Archive

- **Subproject 131:** West was a well-known CIA contractor who received funding to study **dissociative states** and counterculture behavior.
- **Recruitment:** West maintained a "laboratory" in the Haight-Ashbury district during the "Summer of Love" to observe the effects of LSD on the local population, leading to theories that he may have encountered or even influenced members of the **Manson Family** who used the clinic's services.

Would you like to examine the **declassified invoices** or **testimony** from the Senate hearings regarding these specific San Francisco sites?